

uses mostly end up taking their own

QUESTION OF INTEREST

Q Whether the Central Government proposes to give some concessions to small power units generating 25 MW of power. If so, the details thereof; and if not, the reasons for not giving concessions.



RAJAGOPAL LAGADAPATI

Lok Sabha, Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh (INC)

BUSINESS INTERESTS He is the founder chairman of the Lanco Group which has interests in construction, power and property business. Member of CoPU, his Group's client list includes the NHAI.

QUESTION OF INTEREST

Q Whether the Government proposes to start eight-lane access control express highways. If so, the details thereof along with the locations where the expressways are proposed, state-wise and national highway-wise.



NAMMA NAGESWARA RAO

Lok Sabha, Khammam, Andhra Pradesh (TDP)

BUSINESS INTERESTS Non-executive chairman of Madhucon, his Group has the NHAI and Indian Oil Corporation on its client list. He is also a member of the Committee on Public Undertakings.

major role in livelihood in my constituency. Many industrialists ask somebody else to ask questions on their behalf. I am not doing it," says Sambasiva.

Even the precedence of involvement of members in conflict of interest is rare, which may be due to relatively fewer business interests of members in earlier years. In the first Lok Sabha, there were 52 MPs who were industrialists and businessmen; the number went up to 70 in the 13th Lok Sabha and 78 in the 14th, and has touched the 100 mark in the present House. In 2003, the Rajya Sabha witnessed a mild flutter when top hotelier and independent member Lalit Suri asked then finance minister Jaswant Singh about a proposal to impose uniform luxury tax on hotel industry. Singh, instead of answering the question, chose to lecture: "The convention of the House is, where there is a conflict of interest, the honourable member shall not make an inquiry inside the House. As the honourable member is a prominent hotelier and therefore, I would say the question relating to the industry would, under normal circumstances, fall in the category of conflict of interest."

“ There is also a tendency now to read out written speeches in Parliament. This, in some way, raises the doubt that speeches are prepared by others, possibly by business groups. ”

P.J. KURIEN, Member of vice-chairman's panel in the Rajya Sabha



In many democracies, there is a mechanism to monitor and assess the conflict of the member's interest. Meghe says he is yet to assess if his role in the department-related committee on health amounts to conflict of interest or not. "This is a developing situation. It has not become embedded in procedures. Frankly, many members are not cognisant on this matter. We are doing it gradually. There should be a mechanism to encourage the members to declare their interests before they speak," says Karan Singh, chairman, Ethics Committee, who set an example recently by declaring his son's interest in the tourism business before speaking in the Rajya Sabha on it.

Others argue that second jobs of MPs help them make qualitative inputs. "We have required expertise in the sector, which will help enhance the quality of debates. Businessmen

can't be denied their say in Parliament," says Nageswara, who was recently caught in the CoPU stand-off over conflict of interest. Kore also says his experience in the health sector will help the committee to perform and that there is no conflict of interest in his case as his chairmanship is not remunerative. By raising the issue of conflict of interest, nobody is trying to claim scalps but seeking to ensure that the audience be given a chance to form a balanced judgement of the members' arguments.

Khan says it is difficult to regulate the members through law, but they should pursue their moral obligation to declare their interest as advised by the Ethics Committee. "It is not law. It is a code of conduct. It is an advisory," says Khan. He himself was officiating the House when Parimal Nathwani (Independent), who was associated with Reliance, took part in a discus-